To probe the use of such rhetorical strategies, we conducted two analyses. First, we analyzed Twitter data to show how IO officials frame their messaging to emphasize connections with ordinary citizens,[6] resulting in increased public engagement. Second, we used survey experiments to manipulate how IOs are characterized in political rhetoric. Messaging that highlighted IOs' alignment with ordinary people outperformed messages emphasizing technocratic credentials, boosting public support. Finally, we examined how IOs respond to populist threats by centralizing their communications to enhance their social media outreach and the consistency of their public messaging.

These findings illustrate how IOs work to appease domestic audiences in member states and demonstrate that this approach can achieve meaningful success. By engaging directly with publics, IOs not only counter populist resistance but also bolster their legitimacy and relevance in a period of increasing scrutiny.

7.1 Methods of Appeasement

IOs have several means at their disposal to win over domestic audiences and mitigate public hostility. In this section, we explore three approaches: providing tangible goods and services, easing constraints, and issuing direct appeals. We examine each method's potential and pitfalls, ultimately focusing this chapter on the power of rhetorical outreach through social media.

7.1.1 Providing Goods and Services

A widely employed strategy for improving public perceptions is delivering tangible benefits to citizens. Aid organizations, for instance, frequently tailor programs to specific populations. Such targeted assistance often enhances public support for the donor organization (Blair, Marty, and Roessler 2022), particularly as IOs are often seen as more effective and impartial than domestic agencies (Milner, Nielson, and Findley 2016; Dietrich, Mahmud, and Winters 2018).

Branding plays a critical role in this process. Roads, schools, or hospitals built with IO funds often display signage crediting the donor(s). Similarly, food aid packages or social media campaigns may highlight the IO's